

Chapter 6

Old Photographs

The last meeting of the day had finally ended.

Across the twenty-fifth floor, offices were slowly emptying.

One by one, employees gathered their things and disappeared into the elevators, leaving behind the quiet hum of computers and the fading sound of footsteps.

Elara remained at her desk.

A file lay open in front of her, but she had been staring at the same page for several minutes.

Her mind wasn't on work.

It kept returning to the abandoned library.

The footsteps.

The darkness.

That voice.

You shouldn't have come here.

She closed the file with a quiet sigh.

A knock came at the door.

Ethan stepped inside.

"Still working?"

Elara looked up.

"I was."

"Were?"

She gave him a tired look.

"I've lost interest."

"Good. Because it's Friday."

He walked over and leaned against the edge of her desk.

"You've been working all week. Go home."

"I was planning to."

"Planning?"

"Eventually."

Ethan laughed.

"You really haven't changed."

Elara smiled faintly.

"Neither have you."

For a moment, neither of them said anything.

There was something comfortable about the silence between them.

They had known each other for so long that they didn't need to fill every quiet moment.

Ethan glanced at the clock.

"Do you remember how we used to avoid going home on Fridays?"

Elara raised an eyebrow.

"We were college students."

"Exactly. We had no responsibilities."

"You mean no sense of responsibility."

"That too."

She laughed.

Ethan took out his phone.

"Actually..."

He unlocked it.

"I found something."

Elara looked at him suspiciously.

"What?"

"Evidence."

"Of what?"

"Your terrible college decisions."

He opened an old album.

Elara leaned closer.

The first picture appeared.

She laughed immediately.

"Oh my God."

Ethan grinned.

"I know."

He swiped to another.

Then another.

Soon, the quiet office was filled with their laughter.

Some pictures were ridiculous.

Some were embarrassing.

Some were so ordinary that they had once seemed meaningless.

But seeing them now...

made those years feel strangely close.

Ethan stopped at another photograph.

"Do you remember when we bunked Professor Müller's lecture?"

Elara covered her face.

"I remember being forced."

"You agreed."

"Noah literally pulled me out of the classroom."

"And you spent the whole afternoon saying we'd get caught."

"We nearly did."

Ethan laughed.

"We still got away with it."

Elara shook her head, smiling.

Then she looked at the screen again.

"Send me these."

"All of them?"

"Yes."

She laughed softly.

"I want them."

Ethan nodded.

"Okay."

He continued scrolling.

Another picture.

Then another.

Until he reached one from their college trip to the beach.

He stopped.

The photograph showed all six of them together.

The sea stretched behind them beneath the fading evening light.

Daniel was standing in the middle wearing a ridiculous costume that made him look completely out of place.

Noah was laughing beside him.

Ethan was watching Daniel with the same amused expression he always had whenever Daniel did something stupid.

Eva was laughing too.

Elara sat nearby in the sand, her hair moving with the sea breeze, her face bright with genuine laughter.
And Roman...
Roman wasn't looking at the camera.
He was looking at Elara.
A small smile rested on his face.
Not for the picture.
For her.
Elara stared at the screen.
Her smile slowly faded.
For a moment, she forgot that Ethan was sitting beside her.
She only saw a version of herself she barely recognized now.
Happy.
Carefree.
Unaware of how much her life would change.
"You remember that day?" Ethan asked quietly.
Elara nodded.
"Yeah."
A faint smile returned.
"Daniel really thought that costume looked good."
Ethan laughed.
"He still does."
She laughed too.
For a few seconds, everything felt easy again.
Then Ethan swiped to the next picture.
His finger stopped.
His expression changed.
Only for a moment.
Elara noticed.
"What?"
"Nothing."
He locked his phone.
"Why did you stop?"
Ethan gave her a small smile.
"I'll send them later."

Elara studied his face for a second.

Then she let it go.

"Fine."

She stood and picked up her bag.

"It's getting late."

Ethan nodded.

"Come on."

They left the office together.

The elevator carried them down through the quiet building.

Neither of them mentioned the photograph again.

But the image stayed in Elara's mind.

Especially Roman's smile.

By the time Elara reached home, the house was quiet.

She went upstairs, changed into comfortable clothes and sat on the edge of her bed.

Her phone vibrated.

A notification appeared.

Ethan sent you 17 photos.

Elara smiled.

She opened them.

One after another, old memories filled the screen.

College halls.

Friends laughing.

Random moments.

Places they had almost forgotten.

She smiled at some.

Laughed at others.

Then she reached the beach photograph again.

Her eyes stopped on Roman.

She stared for a few seconds longer than she meant to.

Then she locked the phone and placed it beside her.

The room fell quiet.

Outside, Frankfurt glowed beneath the night sky.

For some reason...

the photograph stayed in her mind long after the screen had gone dark.

Saturday morning arrived quietly.

There was no alarm.

No meeting.

No rushing through breakfast.

Sunlight slipped through the curtains and spread across Elara's room.

She opened her eyes slowly.

For a moment, she simply lay there.

Then she reached for her phone.

The photographs from the night before were still open.

She looked at the beach picture once more.

A quiet smile touched her lips.

She finally got out of bed and went downstairs.

Her father was already sitting at the dining table, reading the newspaper.

Her mother was arranging breakfast.

"Good morning," her father said.

"Morning, Dad."

He lowered the newspaper and looked at her.

"You actually slept in."

"It's Saturday."

Her mother smiled.

"Let her enjoy it."

Elara sat down.

For a while, breakfast was peaceful.

No meetings.

No deadlines.

No business discussions.

Just a normal morning.

Then her father folded the newspaper and looked at her.

"So..."

"What are your plans for today?"

Elara thought for a moment.

"Nothing."

"Good."

She looked at him suspiciously.

"Why?"

He smiled.

"Because I have another plan for you."

Her mother glanced at him.

"You're still doing that?"

Elara looked between them.

"Doing what?"

Her father simply smiled.

"You'll find out."

"That sounds suspicious."

"It's not."

"That's exactly what someone suspicious would say."

Her father laughed.

Even Elara couldn't hold back her smile.

But there was something about his expression...

Something that told her this weekend wasn't going to be as quiet as she had expected.

She just didn't know yet...

where it would take her.